

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 750

By Atchley

A RESOLUTION to recognize Sevier County Mayor Larry Waters, the longest-serving elected official in Tennessee, on the occasion of his retirement.

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly should specially recognize those Tennesseans who have performed with uncommon devotion and ability throughout their careers in public service; and

WHEREAS, one such outstanding person is Sevier County Mayor Larry Waters, who is taking a well-earned retirement in 2026 after a distinguished career that has spanned more than five decades; and

WHEREAS, a lifelong resident of Sevier County, Larry Waters earned a Bachelor of Science degree in Business Administration from the University of Tennessee in 1974; after teaching for one year, he became a principal in the Sevier County school system; and

WHEREAS, in 1978, at the age of twenty-five, Mr. Waters ran for office and ultimately became the youngest elected mayor in Tennessee; today, he holds the distinction of being the State's longest-serving elected official, having played an important role in the incredible transformation of his beloved Sevier County and the East Tennessee region over the past forty-seven years; and

WHEREAS, under Mayor Waters's leadership, Sevier County has seen its population more than triple, its operating budget grow nearly twentyfold, and its tourism industry expand to welcome more than twenty-one million visitors annually, ranking the county among the top tourism destinations in the Southeast; and

WHEREAS, his estimable mayoral tenure has included public safety and emergency management improvements, the modernization of county government operations, coordinated industrial recruitment and growth, and significant investment in education and economic

development; he has also worked to build strong relationships between city, county, state, and federal agencies, fostering collaboration and partnership across all levels of government; and

WHEREAS, during his decades of service, Mayor Waters has earned a reputation for steady leadership during times of crisis and upheaval, including the devastating 2016 wildfires and multiple periods of record-breaking tourism growth that required expanded infrastructure and services; he has also been instrumental in advancing major capital projects, including the expansion of the Sevier County Courthouse; and

WHEREAS, as the longest-serving county mayor in Tennessee history, Mayor Waters has worked with generations of elected officials, community leaders, and citizens to shape Sevier County's growth while protecting its character and sense of community; and

WHEREAS, through his ability to cast vision for the future, unify leaders, and manage both tremendous growth and incredible challenges, Mayor Waters has effectively preserved and advanced the collective interests of the citizens of Sevier County and their visitors; and

WHEREAS, his legacy was appropriately commemorated when the Tennessee County Services Association named its Mayor of the Year Award in his honor and selected Larry Waters as its inaugural recipient in 2023; and

WHEREAS, he has earned numerous other laurels, including the 2003 Pless R. Newman Republican Services Award, the 2013 Boy Scouts Sequoyah District Great Smoky Mountain Council Good Scout Award, and the 2010 Robert M. Wormsley Outstanding County Official of the Year Award; he has been honored by East Tennessee State University (ETSU) as an Honorary Alumnus and by the University of Tennessee as an Outstanding Alumnus; and

WHEREAS, Larry Waters has given back to his community far beyond his accomplishments as Sevier County Mayor, having served in many leadership positions and offices throughout his career, including with the United Way Campaign, Leadership Sevier and Leadership Knoxville, Tennessee County Services Association, Tennessee Development

District Association, East Tennessee Development District, East Tennessee Human Resources Agency, Association of County Mayors of Tennessee, Tennessee Air Pollution Control Board, Sevier County Republican Party, Tennessee Advisory Commission on Intergovernmental Relations, East Tennessee Economic Development Agency, Sevier County Economic Development Council, County Executives of America, and NACO Membership Committee; and

WHEREAS, passionate about the importance of education in producing a stronger and more stable workforce and providing a higher quality of life in the region, Mayor Waters is a past chairman and current member of the board of Carson-Newman Board of Trustees and has served as chairman and executive of the University of Tennessee Chancellor's Associates; and

WHEREAS, as an organizer and founding member of the ETSU-Sevier County Health Sciences Partnership, Mayor Waters played a significant role in founding The Sevier Center; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Waters is an active member of the First Baptist Church of Gatlinburg, having formerly served as chairman and currently serving as deacon; and

WHEREAS, a devoted family man, Larry Waters is most grateful for the love and support of his wife, Terri, who has her own art studio in Gatlinburg; their son, David, who operates a travel company locally and in two other states; their daughter, Adrienne, who is the first woman to serve as circuit court judge in the Fourth Judicial District, and her husband, Bart Ogle; and their grandchildren, Caden and Camilla Waters and Charlotte and Amelia Ogle; and

WHEREAS, this humble, caring man modestly asserts that "serving as Sevier County Mayor has truly been the honor of a lifetime" and is grateful for the trust the people of Sevier County have placed in him for the past forty-seven years; and

WHEREAS, Mayor Waters has announced that he will not be seeking reelection in 2026, thus concluding a remarkable career of inspired leadership in service of Sevier County and the East Tennessee region; and

WHEREAS, Larry Waters has been a visionary in local and regional economic development during his tenure as Sevier County Mayor, and he should be specially recognized on this special occasion; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor and commend Larry Waters, the longest-serving elected official in Tennessee, upon his unprecedented tenure as Sevier County Mayor, salute his ongoing commitment to his community and its progress, and extend to him our best wishes for a happy and fulfilling retirement.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.